

Episode 1 — Pitch Round v2

Engineered against the Pilot Doctrine (spec v2) · openings are verbatim node text · 10 July 2026

Round-one lesson applied throughout: attachment is the pilot's output, never its input. Every candidate below builds Ally's warmth and competence on-page inside the first two leads, gives Gerald an engineered entrance that creates the attachment later scenes will spend, builds its victim from one concrete detail, and reaches Ally personally by the midpoint. Doctrine scorecards are printed per pitch; comparison matrix and recommendation on the final page.

The Listener

"My loneliest listener stopped calling. In her last call, behind her voice, someone else is breathing."

LOGLINE

Between midnight and two, Ally's show belongs to the callers — and for three years the last call of every week has been Marnie from Rivermouth, an elderly widow who always signs off the same way: *say goodnight to the harbour for me, Ally*. Then two weeks of silence. When Ally replays Marnie's final call, she hears a second person breathing inside the house — listening to Marnie talk to her. Ally has thousands of listeners and never asked one lonely woman her last name. Now she has to reconstruct an entire life from three years of call-in audio before whoever was in that house decides Marnie saw too much from her window over the water.

THE VICTIM & THE DETAIL

Marnie Kowalczyk, 72 — widow, insomniac, riverside cottage in Rivermouth. The detail: *"say goodnight to the harbour for me"* — last call of the night, every week, three years. The player hears it once and will never forget it; the episode's final scene pays it off.

THE KEEPER

Ally herself carries this one — the guilt engine is that the show is the only family Marnie had, and the show never asked her name. (Secondary: Marnie's sister, found mid-episode.) Every lead the player completes visibly rebuilds Marnie's identity from her own recorded voice: the player is literally assembling the person nobody bothered to know.

THE SECRET

Marnie's window overlooks the Rivermouth reach, and on slow nights she'd chat on air about "the quiet boats" that pass with no lights. Someone whose boats those are finally heard the broadcasts. A man entered her house twice — once silently (the breathing on the final call), once as a gas inspector. Marnie, sharper than anyone credits, got scared and vanished to her estranged sister's place in the hills without telling a soul — because there was no soul to tell, except a radio show. The breathing man was never there to hurt her; he was there to establish what she could see. He left something behind on her radio to mark the house as handled: a coin.

REVEAL LADDER

1. The final call, filtered: a second person breathing, ~4 metres from Marnie's chair. She never knew.
2. Audio forensics on 3 years of calls (the player's evidence corpus): her street reconstructed from bells, gulls, a swing-bridge — Gerald names the bridge in one listen.
3. Her cottage, found: mail piled, radio still on, tuned to Ally's station. On top of the radio, a coin. (*planted, unexplained*)
4. The "gas inspector" visit — a neighbour's doorbell camera; nobody official scheduled it. Someone checked her sightlines.

5. The motive inversion (midpoint gut-punch): the calls themselves. "The quiet boats." **She was targeted because of the show.** Ally's show. Jeopardy lands on Ally: whoever listened to Marnie has been listening to *her*.
6. Climax: the pharmacy-script/parish-newsletter trail ends at the sister's hill cottage — Marnie alive, furious at the fuss, secretly desperate to be found.

THE BRANCH (PHASE 2)

Air the breathing. Play the filtered audio on the show — the city's ten thousand ears might place the man, but he learns exactly how much Ally has. **Or hold it back** — Del Cruz's ask — and hunt with a quieter net while a frightened old woman stays missing a day longer. Cost either way; both paths converge on the sister's cottage with one scene changed and one finale line changed.

GERALD'S ENGINEERED ENTRANCE

Ally brings him the filtered audio at the Anchor expecting comfort. He puts on the headphones, and where anyone else would flinch at the breathing, he *turns the volume up*. Thirty seconds later: "Swing-bridge counterweight. Rivermouth reach — the old crossing sings when the boats run late." One scene: his competence (a detective's ear), his warmth (he stays up the rest of the night making a list of every bridge he's ever heard), and his relationship to Ally (she came to him first) — attachment built, not assumed.

DOCTRINE SCORECARD

Dramatic question ≤2 nodes	Node 2: the breathing. Unwalkable-away-from.
Ally warmth beat (L1–L2)	She noticed one silent voice among thousands — and says goodnight to the harbour herself, on air, in case Marnie can hear.
Ally competence beat (L1–L2)	Audio forensics on-page: isolates the breathing, reads a limp in its rhythm from a chair creak.
Grievable victim, one detail	"Say goodnight to the harbour for me."
Engineered entrances	Gerald: the volume-up scene. Del Cruz: enters refusing to open a case for "an adult who stopped phoning a radio station" — then quietly runs the doorbell footage anyway (her pattern: rules bent, off the record).
Jeopardy on Ally by midpoint	Reveal 5: the show itself is the reason. He has heard every episode.
Vulnerability beat	Ally, alone, locket open: her father interviewed strangers for a living and knew every name; she monetised loneliness and never asked one. Am I the show he'd have made?
Guided tour	L2–L3: process the call archive (merge = filtering hours of audio), visit the cottage (evidence lead). The engine IS the case.
Effort engine	Each lead audibly restores Marnie: a name, a street, a sister. The player assembles a person from a voice.
Whiff of change + coin	Coin on the radio, never explained. Change: Ally ends knowing the show has one listener she never wanted — final line: "He listens. Good. Then he heard me say I don't scare." Season armed.

CANON & NEW FACES

Rivermouth Industrial (riverside cottages), the Rusty Anchor (Gerald's scene; Mo pours and says nothing, which says everything), Del Cruz (engineered entrance above), Kestrel Point fog for the hills drive. New portraits: Marnie (one unforgettable face), her sister, the deckhand-neighbour. The coin/night-boats whisper quietly seeds Episode 2's "where does the route land?" — the answer was on Marnie's window the whole time.

THE RESOLUTION BEAT

Final podcast node: mid-sign-off, the call board lights. Last call of the night. "Say goodnight to the harbour for me, Ally." — "Say it yourself, Marnie. You're on the air." The episode's first detail becomes its last line.

OPENING — L1 · "LAST CALL" (PODCAST, VO)

	SPEAKER	EMOTION	LINE
1	Ally	neutral	Between midnight and two, my show belongs to the callers. Truckers. Nurses. People the dark forgot to put to bed. And every week for three years, the last call of the night: Marnie from Rivermouth. Same sign-off, every time. Say goodnight to the harbour for me, Ally.
2	Ally	worried	Two weeks ago — nothing. Last week — nothing. So last night I pulled her final call and put on headphones. Behind her voice, four metres from her chair, someone else is breathing. Inside her house. Listening to her talk to me.
3	Ally	neutral	Three years, and I never asked her last name. Thousands of listeners, and I let one voice be enough. So tonight I ran that call through every filter I own. The breathing has a rhythm. The rhythm has a flaw — a chair creak on every second step. He's real. He limps. He was in her house.
4	Ally	neutral	Marnie, if you can hear me: goodnight, the harbour misses you. Everyone else — this is Echoes of Havenbay. This week, the show comes to find you.

The Girl Who Waved

"For six years she waved good morning at the 7:40 ferry. Last Tuesday she waved for help."

LOGLINE

Every commuter on the 7:40 Harbor Ward ferry knows her: third floor, corner window, the building with the blue door — one raised hand, every morning, six years. Nobody knows her name. Ally rides that ferry and waves back, and last Tuesday she saw the wave change: palm out, thumb folded, fingers closing over it — the international signal for *help me, I can't say it aloud*. Wednesday the window was empty. To find a woman the whole city saw and never knew, Ally has to reconstruct a life from a window: the geometry of a wave, a weekly grave visit, and the estate of a dead harbour paymaster whose family decided his carer was an asset that transferred with the furniture.

THE VICTIM & THE DETAIL

Alma Reyes-Santos, 34 — live-in carer to Abel Marsh, retired harbour paymaster, dead three weeks. The detail: *the wave itself* — six years, one raised hand, an entire city's mornings made slightly better by a stranger. The signal turns the city's warmest habit into its most urgent question. (Bonus: the help signal is real; the episode quietly teaches ten thousand players what it looks like.)

THE KEEPER

Tomas, the ferry deckhand who has returned the wave longer than anyone and keeps a photo of "the waving window" on the wheelhouse corkboard — and, in aggregate, *the commuters*: the episode makes the whole city the keeper, and pays them off together.

THE SECRET

When Marsh died, his nephew inherited the building — and found a carer six weeks in wage arrears, paperwork "held for safekeeping," with nowhere to go. He moved her to his property near Kestrel Point as unpaid "help" against a debt he invented. No chains, no cinematic villainy: just a locked-away passport, a tallied debt, and the quiet arithmetic of someone with no one — the kind of exploitation that hides in plain sight, which is the episode's thesis and the show's. Alma signalled the only people she trusted: the ferry that had waved back for six years.

REVEAL LADDER

1. The signal identified (node 3 of the cold open) — and the window is empty by Wednesday.
2. The window found: Ally triangulates it from two years of her own ferry photos — light angles, reflections, the blue door. Competence on-page.
3. The room, emptied — but the building's post: wage slips (stopped six weeks before Marsh died), and a fresh-flowers receipt, weekly, harbour cemetery.
4. The grave: Abel Marsh. Flowers changed *yesterday*. She's alive, local, still kind. (Midpoint lift — and jeopardy turn: someone else has noticed the flowers too; Ally is photographed at the grave by a man who doesn't leave a name.)

5. The nephew: Marsh's estate, the "debt," the second property. The man from the cemetery — his fixer, warning her off with a visit to the studio's buzzer at 2 a.m.
6. Climax at the Kestrel Point property; Del Cruz arrives with the part of the law that actually works fast: document withholding and wage theft.

THE BRANCH (PHASE 2)

Broadcast the window — ask the 7:40's thousand riders what they've seen over six years (the city solves it faster; the nephew learns the city is looking and moves her again) — **or trace quiet** through the estate paperwork while the flowers are still fresh. The player chooses between the loud warmth of the crowd and the slow safety of the file.

GERALD'S ENGINEERED ENTRANCE

Ally shows him the photo of the building. He doesn't look at the window — he looks at the door. "Blue door. That was Marsh's boarding house. Paymaster at the harbour, back when pay came in envelopes. Careful man. Counted everything twice." A beat. "Men who count everything twice always die owing somebody." His entrance demonstrates the thing only Gerald provides: forty years of the city's memory, delivered dry.

DOCTRINE SCORECARD

Dramatic question ≤2 nodes	Node 2–3: the wave changes; the window empties.
Ally warmth beat (L1–L2)	Established in node 2: she has waved back for two years — "you do it before you decide to." Deepened L2: she rides the early ferry with coffee for Tomas.
Ally competence beat (L1–L2)	The window triangulation from her own photo roll — geometry, light, reflections. Visual, brilliant, hers.
Grievable victim, one detail	The wave. Six years of it. The whole city already loves her without knowing it — the pilot just tells them.
Engineered entrances	Gerald: the blue-door memory scene. Mo: the Anchor is where ferry crews drink; she produces three regulars who "know the waving girl" in one night. Del Cruz: the climax, choosing the enforceable statute.
Jeopardy on Ally by midpoint	Reveal 4–5: photographed at the grave; the 2 a.m. buzzer. Followed, named, warned.
Vulnerability beat	Locket, ferry deck, dawn: her father waved her off to school from the Gazette steps every morning until he didn't. "You wave back. That's the whole religion."
Guided tour	L2 evidence (photo triangulation), L3 place (the building) — the loop taught through a rescue, not a tutorial.
Effort engine	Every lead moves flowers-fresh hope forward; the player is the search party the city never sent.
Whiff of change + coin	In Marsh's effects Alma protected: a paymaster's ledger scrap and one coin she couldn't explain. Change: Ally ends the episode riding the 7:40 as a different person — "I used to wave at a window. Now I count who's missing from them."

CANON & NEW FACES

Harbor Ward ferry, Kestrel Point, the Rusty Anchor (ferry crews' bar; Mo's scene), Del Cruz in her ward, Gerald's city-memory. Marsh's paymaster history whispers at the harbour-money season thread without naming it. New portraits: Alma, Tomas, the nephew.

THE RESOLUTION BEAT

The following Tuesday, 7:40 sharp: the whole ferry — tipped off by the show — turns to the empty window and waves goodbye to it together, because Alma isn't in it. She's on the deck beside Ally, waving back at her window for the first time. Tomas sounds the horn. Nobody in the beta will get through it dry.

OPENING — L1 · "THE 7:40" (PODCAST, VO)

	SPEAKER	EMOTION	LINE
1	Ally	neutral	If you've ever ridden the 7:40 ferry out of Harbor Ward, you know her. Third floor, corner window, the building with the blue door. Six years of mornings. One raised hand. The commuters call her the Waving Girl. Nobody knows her name.
2	Ally	neutral	I ride that ferry. I've waved back for two years — you do it before you decide to. Last Tuesday, the wave was different. Palm out. Thumb folded. Fingers closing over it. Twice.
3	Ally	surprised	One search. That's all it took to learn what it means. It's a signal — built for people who are watched, so they can ask for help without making a sound. Wednesday morning, the window was empty. It has been empty since.
4	Ally	neutral	Six years, and the whole city saw her every morning and never learned her name. I'm going to learn her name. This is Echoes of Havenbay. Say it with me: we see you.

The Boy Who Said Yes

"Danny Calder confessed in fourteen hours. His letters have been asking the same question for six years: does anyone believe me yet?"

LOGLINE

In 2019, nineteen-year-old Danny Calder sat in an interview room for fourteen hours with no lawyer, no parent, and no food, and finally said the only words anyone remembers him for: *yes, it was me*. A night clerk had died during a servo robbery; the city needed a name; Danny — young, tired, and kind — was told, falsely and legally, that his girlfriend had already placed him at the scene. Every Tuesday since, a letter arrives at his sister's flat, spelling improving year by year, ending with the same question. In nineteen days Danny faces a parole board that will free him if he performs remorse for something he didn't do — and Ally has until then to prove the confession false, find who the robbery was really for, and answer a Tuesday letter honestly for the first time in six years.

THE VICTIM & THE DETAIL

Danny Calder, 25 — six years inside on a false confession. The detail: *the Tuesday letters* — six years of them, spelling improving year by year (he's taught himself to read properly in prison), each ending *does anyone believe me yet?*

THE KEEPER

Grace Calder, 29 — his sister, who has answered every letter and never once written the word "yes" because she won't lie to him twice. She works doubles at the Corner Diner; the player's effort visibly converts her file box of letters into a case.

THE SECRET

The confession is textbook false: the "false evidence ploy" (legal, real, devastating on the young and exhausted). The robbery wasn't a robbery — the servo was a cash handling point, and the "robber" was collecting a package the clerk had decided not to hand over; the clerk's heart gave out, the pickup man fled with the package, and the till was staged after. Danny, walking home two streets over, fit the description because a description was needed. The pickup man was never caught because nobody was ever really looking — and the evidence box contains one item the log never listed: a coin.

REVEAL LADDER

1. The interrogation tape (long buried in disclosure): fourteen hours, the false girlfriend line at hour nine, the "yes" at hour fourteen — in a voice that's just asking to go home.
2. The girlfriend, found: she never made a statement. Hearing what was said in her name breaks something loose — she keeps the receipt that puts Danny two streets away at 11:52.
3. The till roll vs. the autopsy clock: the register was opened *after* the clerk's death. Staged. Not a robbery.
4. Gerald reads the file and goes quiet in a way Ally has never seen (midpoint): the interrogating detective learned the ploy from Gerald's generation — "we taught them that." His stake is shame; the case becomes

his amends. Jeopardy turn: Ally's records request pings someone — her appointment at the records office is cancelled from inside.

5. The servo's cash-point history: a route stop. The package. The pickup man — old now, comfortable, local, and aware of her.
6. Climax — the parole hearing (and the branch's consequence): the recantation, the receipt, and the till-roll timeline filed as a conviction referral, live on the show.

THE BRANCH (PHASE 2) — THE PAROLE PARADOX

The board frees men who show remorse and keeps men who "lack insight." Ally gets one visit. **Advise Danny to perform remorse** — walk free in weeks as a liar, the referral fights on from outside — **or hold his innocence** — stay inside while the truth grinds through, dignity intact. This is a real, documented cruelty of parole systems, players will argue about it for days, and either answer is defensible and costs something. The strongest branch of any pitch in either round.

GERALD'S ENGINEERED ENTRANCE

Reveal 4 is his entrance, moved early into Phase 1 by design: he reads two pages of the interrogation transcript at his booth, closes the folder, and orders a drink Mo has never seen him order. "I know this play, love. I helped write it." The pilot doesn't ask you to love Gerald — it shows you a man meeting his own history and choosing the right side of it. Attachment through shame carried with dignity: the most Gerald thing possible.

DOCTRINE SCORECARD

Dramatic question ≤2 nodes	Node 2: six years of Tuesday letters, one question. The player wants to answer it.
Ally warmth beat (L1–L2)	She answers the newest letter before she has any evidence — with the only honest sentence available: "I don't know yet. But I'm looking." First person in six years to look.
Ally competence beat (L1–L2)	She spots the case in one read: confession says left hand on the till; the clerk's bruising says right. Nobody compared them in six years.
Grievable victim, one detail	The Tuesday letters, spelling improving year by year.
Engineered entrances	Gerald: the folder scene ("I helped write it"). Del Cruz: refuses to touch it — "cops don't reopen cops" — then leaves the disclosure box number on a napkin. Mo: the drink she's never poured him.
Jeopardy on Ally by midpoint	Reveal 4: the cancelled records appointment — someone inside the system is watching her requests.
Vulnerability beat	Locket, night before the parole visit: her father was accused of "chasing ghosts" his whole career. What if I'm about to tell an innocent man to lie — or a guilty one that I believe him?
Guided tour	L2 letters/interview (person), L3 disclosure box (evidence) — merging processes a six-year paper mountain.

Effort engine	Grace's letter box converts, lead by lead, into exhibits. The player builds the answer to Danny's question with their hands.
Whiff of change + coin	The unlogged coin in the evidence box. Change: the final Tuesday letter is read aloud on air by Grace — the new last line: "Someone believes me." Ally ends the pilot having promised the show will always answer its mail.

CANON & NEW FACES

Corner Diner (Grace's doubles; the diner item family earns its story place), the Rusty Anchor (Gerald's folder scene, Mo's pour), Del Cruz (the napkin), Rivermouth servo, Civic Row courts. Season texture: the cash-point route without naming the network. New portraits: Danny, Grace, the girlfriend.

THE RESOLUTION BEAT

Danny is still inside when the credits roll — referrals take months, and the episode is honest about it. But the final scene is Grace at the diner counter after close, reading her Tuesday reply aloud as Ally airs it: the first letter in six years that opens with the word *Yes*.

OPENING — L1 · "FOURTEEN HOURS" (PODCAST, VO)

	SPEAKER	EMOTION	LINE
1	Ally	neutral	In 2019, nineteen-year-old Danny Calder sat in an interview room for fourteen hours — no lawyer, no parent, nothing to eat since breakfast — and then said the only words anyone remembers him for. Yes. It was me.
2	Ally	sad	Every Tuesday since, a letter arrives at his sister's flat. Six years of Tuesdays. The handwriting gets steadier every year — he taught himself inside. The last line never changes: does anyone believe me yet?
3	Ally	worried	Here's what fourteen hours does to nineteen: at hour nine they told him his girlfriend had put him at the scene. She hadn't. She was never even asked. That's called the false evidence ploy. It's legal. And it works best on the young, the tired, and the kind.
4	Ally	neutral	The evidence never matched the confession — nobody checked, because why would you? He said yes. This is Echoes of Havenbay. Danny Calder meets the parole board in nineteen days, and this show answers its mail.

Scoring the Round

RUBRIC MATRIX (PILOT SPEC, 1–5)

CRITERION	D · LISTENER	E · WAVED	F · SAID YES
Cold-open strength	5	5	4
Present-tense jeopardy	5	4	3
Emotional keeper / resolution beat	5	5	5
One-sentence clarity	5	5	4
Canon nativeness	4	5	4
Whisper elegance (coin)	5	4	3
Branch quality	4	3	5
Teachability (first 3 leads)	5	5	4
Ally attachment engineering	5	5	4
Shareability (short-form clip potential)	4	5	4
Total /50	47	46	40

RECOMMENDATION

D — The Listener — with E as a photo-finish second, and one franken-option worth naming.

Why D: it is the most *podcast-native* story possible — the crime scene is audio, the evidence is the show's own archive, and the villain's motive is the show itself, which means the season's antagonist and the player's chosen activity become the same thing. Its guilt engine gives Ally the richest interior arc of the round; its final scene ("Say it yourself, Marnie — you're on the air") pays off the episode's first detail with the episode's whole thesis; and its coin placement quietly seeds Episode 2's exact open question. The jeopardy is the most personal of any pitch in either round: *he listens to the show* is a sentence that changes every subsequent episode the player hears.

Why E runs it so close: the wave is the most instantly grievable image we have generated, the resolution beat is the most cathartic, and it's the most clippable for short-form marketing (the help-signal hook is practically a public-service TikTok). If you want the pilot to lead with warmth over dread, choose E.

F is the boldest and owns the best branch (the parole paradox), but its jeopardy is systemic rather than physical and its clock, while real, ticks quietly. It is arguably the best *episode* — for mid-season, where its anger lands on an audience already in love. Recommend banking it as Episode 3 or 4.

The franken-option: D's case with F's branch philosophy — make D's on-air choice (air the breathing / hold it) carry parole-paradox-grade moral weight by attaching Del Cruz's career to the broadcast decision. And E's ferry-wave resolution beat is a template worth stealing for any episode: the city, paying one person back, together.